

How Stories Start Wars — and How to Change Them

An easy-to-read guide for anyone, in any government, in any country

This document explains a simple method for spotting dangerous stories about other countries — and replacing them with honest ones that make cooperation more likely than conflict. Every section below stands on its own. You do not need to remember anything from an earlier page to understand a later one, even if that means a few ideas are repeated more than once. That repetition is intentional.

1. The Big Idea, in Three Sentences

Wars almost never start with a weapon. They start with a story — a story that makes the weapon feel necessary, or even right. If you can catch the dangerous story early, and offer people a better one that still serves their real interests, you can often stop the conflict before it starts.

2. What We Mean by “a Story”

By “story” (also called a narrative), we simply mean the explanation a country, a leader, or a media outlet gives for why something is happening in the world — for example, “our rise is unstoppable,” or “they have always been our enemy,” or “we had no choice but to act.” A story can be mostly true, mostly false, or a mix of both. What matters most is not just whether a story is true, but whether it is pushing people toward working together, or toward conflict.

3. The Four Warning Signs of a Dangerous Story

Whether the story comes from your own country or another one, watch for these four things. They show up in almost every story that leads toward conflict:

- It says the bad outcome is inevitable — “this was always going to happen” — which makes people feel there is no point trying to stop it.
- It makes the other side sound evil or dishonest by nature, not just wrong about one thing — which makes it feel pointless to negotiate with them.
- It only offers two choices — “us or them,” “strength or weakness” — when in reality there is almost always a middle path.
- It leans on an old grievance or hurt from the past to justify a new, present-day action — which makes any compromise today feel like a betrayal of history.

Important: these four warning signs show up on every side of every conflict. A country that only looks for these signs in its rivals' stories, and never in its own, is not being honest — it is just doing propaganda with extra steps.

4. Why Just Telling the Truth Usually Isn't Enough

Here is an uncomfortable but well-documented fact: if someone already believes a dangerous story, simply showing them true facts often makes them believe it more strongly, not less. This is not a reason to stop telling the truth. It is a reason to stop expecting the truth to work on its own. The truth needs to be paired with a reason for people to actually want to believe it — in other words, with carrots (rewards) and sticks (costs), not just facts.

5. The Six-Step Method, Explained Simply

This is the heart of the whole approach. Each step is a plain question you can ask about any story you hear about another country, before you decide whether to believe it or repeat it.

- Step 1 — Who is telling me this, and what do they gain if I believe it? A billionaire, a TV channel, and a government all have their own reasons for telling a story a certain way. Knowing their reason does not make them wrong, but it tells you how carefully to check what they say.
- Step 2 — Which part is a fact, and which part is just a way of describing the fact? “More leaders are visiting this country” can be a plain fact. “This proves they will soon rule the world” is a way of describing that fact — one of many possible ways.
- Step 3 — What would make the storyteller want to tell a different, more honest story? Usually, people keep repeating a story because it currently benefits them somehow — attention, money, political support. Ask what would have to change for a truer story to also be the more rewarding one.
- Step 4 — Can I offer a truer story that still lets everyone involved save face and get something they want? A better story is much more likely to be accepted if no one has to admit total defeat to adopt it.
- Step 5 — Who does my audience already trust, and can that trusted messenger help share the truer story? A fact is far more likely to be believed coming from a source people already trust than from a stranger, however accurate the stranger is.
- Step 6 — What actually changed in the real world — not just in the headlines? Did policy change? Did trade change? Did a vote change? That is the only way to know if the truer story actually worked.

6. Real Example One: The Billionaire and the YouTube Channel

In mid-2026, the well-known investor Ray Dalio said he saw signs that other countries were starting to treat China with the kind of deference nations once showed a dominant regional power — something he called a “tribute system.” A YouTube channel called China Uncensored, which is known for being strongly critical of China's government, made a video reacting to this, titled “This billionaire says China should rule the world.”

Applying the six steps above: Dalio has decades of direct contact with senior Chinese officials, which gives his view real weight, but he also has a financial incentive to say attention-grabbing things. China Uncensored has publicly said its channel has faced revenue pressure, which gives it an incentive to use the most alarming possible title. When you check the actual words, Dalio never said China “should”

rule the world, and he specifically said he does not expect China to become an aggressive military power — so the video's title is a dramatic description of his view, not a quote of it. The honest, more useful story is not “is China destined to rule the world,” but the checkable question: is trust in the old alliance system actually weakening, and if so, what should any given country do to remain a trusted, reliable partner regardless of who ends up more powerful?

7. Real Example Two: The Professor and the Chinese Newspaper

In July 2026, the American economist Jeffrey Sachs — a real, credentialed professor at Columbia University who has also advised the United Nations — wrote an article arguing that the United States should return to its own founding values of respecting other nations and avoiding permanent foreign alliances. The article was published in China Daily, a newspaper owned and run by the Chinese government.

Applying the six steps above: Sachs is a genuine, serious scholar, not a fringe figure, and the historical quotes he uses from the Declaration of Independence; George Washington; Thomas Jefferson; and the original Monroe Doctrine are all real and accurate — you can check them yourself using the links at the end of this document. But the article was published only through a Chinese state-run newspaper, which naturally benefits when a respected American voice makes an argument that lines up with what the Chinese government would also like Americans to believe. The article also states as flat fact that recent American and Israeli military strikes on Iran were “a blatant war of aggression” — but legal experts are actually divided on that exact legal question, so presenting it as settled is a way of describing events, not a plain fact. The genuinely useful and checkable part of the article — the founders' own words about respecting other nations and avoiding permanent foreign entanglements — can be used honestly by any country's government, regardless of which newspaper first published this particular article about them.

8. What These Two Examples Prove Together

Taken together, these two real examples show the method works the same way no matter which side of a rivalry the story comes from. A story critical of (China from a Western, anti-China channel) and a story critical of the (United States from a Chinese state newspaper) both deserve exactly the same four checks: who benefits, what part is fact versus framing, what would change the storyteller's incentive, and what a fairer story would look like. Treating both sides by the same standard is what makes this approach trustworthy rather than just another opinion.

9. Carrots and Sticks, in Plain Terms

Carrots are the rewards that make choosing an honest, cooperative story worthwhile. Sticks are the real costs of sticking with a false or aggressive one. Appealing to someone's honesty alone rarely works with governments or powerful institutions — what works is showing them that telling the truth is also in their own interest.

CARROTS — reasons to choose the honest story	STICKS — costs of sticking with the false one
• Being trusted opens doors — trade deals, invitations to help set the rules, a seat at the table • Being seen as reliable is worth money — countries and companies pay more to work with <u>partners they trust</u> • Letting the <u>other side help</u> write the new story means they have a reason to defend it, not fight it	• Getting caught in a false story <u>costs trust</u> that takes years to rebuild • Being publicly shown to have exaggerated or <u>lied makes future claims</u> easier to dismiss • Being <u>excluded</u> from trade deals, alliances, or talks is a <u>real, immediate cost</u> — not just embarrassment

10. What Any Government Can Actually Do With This, Starting Now

- Before a minister or official responds publicly to a dramatic story about another country, have a small team quickly check **who** is telling the story and what they **gain** from it.
- Never repeat a claim about another country using only one source — always check it against at least one source that would have a different point of view.
- When correcting a false or exaggerated story, offer the **other side** a way to accept the correction without losing face — this makes acceptance far more likely.
- Publish how your own government checks these stories, so your own citizens and other countries can see you hold yourself to the same standard you expect from others.

11. A Few Honest Warnings About This Method Itself

- This method can be misused. The same four warning signs used here to spot a dangerous story could also be used, in bad faith, to build one. The only real protection against that is always checking your own side's stories with the same care you use on everyone else's.
- This method cannot settle deep legal or moral disagreements by itself — such as whether a particular military strike was legal. What it can do is make clear which parts of a disagreement are checkable facts, which parts are genuine legal disputes, and which parts are simply one side's way of describing events.
- Not every disagreement has two equally valid sides. Sometimes one side really is more accurate than the other. Treating every story as “equally balanced” when the facts do not support that would itself be a distortion, not fairness.

12. Where to Check Everything in This Document Yourself

- Ray Dalio's own essay on the “tribute system” (the original source for Example One - #6)
- Background on the China Uncensored YouTube channel (for Example One - #6)
- Jeffrey Sachs's article in China Daily, July 3, 2026 (the original source for Example Two - #7)
- Jeffrey Sachs's own website and article archive, for comparison
- A neutral, non-partisan UK government timeline of the 2026 Iran strikes mentioned in (Example Two - #7)
- An independent encyclopedia overview of the 2026 Iran war, for further background

13. One-Sentence Summary

Check who benefits from a story, separate the facts from the framing, and offer people a truer story they are actually rewarded for choosing — and do this the same way for every country, including your own.

References

- Jeffrey Sachs, "US at 250" (China Daily, July 3, 2026): <https://www.chinadaily.com.cn/a/202607/03/WS6a471746a310986e2b463543.html>
- Jeffrey Sachs's own article archive: <https://www.jeffsachs.org/newspaper-articles>
- Just Security legal analysis collection on the 2026 Iran strikes: <https://www.justsecurity.org/114556/collection-israel-iran-conflict/>
- UK House of Commons Library briefing on the 2026 Iran conflict: <https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-10521/>
- Encyclopaedia Britannica, "2026 Iran war": <https://www.britannica.com/event/2026-Iran-war>
- Ray Dalio, "The Tribute System: The New World Order" (his own essay): <https://raydalio.substack.com/p/the-tribute-system-the-new-world>
- China Uncensored — Wikipedia background: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/China_Uncensored

Original SWOT/Fact-Check Document (Dalio/China Uncensored analysis)

- Bloomberg, "Ray Dalio: 'Expect a Tribute System'" (video): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iB2eApp0Kmo>
- RealClearPolitics transcript of Dalio's remarks: https://www.realclearpolitics.com/video/2026/05/17/ray_dalio_iran_war_tests_american_world_order_as_china_inc_builds_tribute_system.html
- China Uncensored YouTube channel: <https://www.youtube.com/@ChinaUncensored>
- Fortune, on Dalio's 10-day China trip: <https://fortune.com/2026/06/24/ray-dalio-china-tribute-system-america-empire/>
- Arnaud Bertrand, sinological fact-check of Dalio's tribute-system claim: <https://arnaudbertrand.substack.com/p/is-ray-dalio-correct-that-china-is>